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About text descriptions

An introduction on text descriptions, their benefits, and principles.

Part of: **How to write text descriptions (alt text) in BBC News articles**

Contributors



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What are text descriptions (also known as alt text)?

Text descriptions are also known as alt text, or alternative text. We call them 'text descriptions' as for many audiences, text descriptions are not an alternative.

They describe the content and function of digital images or visual elements for people who do not digest information visually.

This includes blind and visually impaired people who use screen reader technology (when information is read out loud) or braille displays (when information is turned into braille form).

The right text description gives these groups equal access to news, and it helps with search engine optimisation. In all, it allows each news article to be as impactful as possible.

It must be considered as editorially important as any other element such as photos, graphics, videos, captions, or the wonderful words you have written.

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The benefits of text descriptions

Value for all underpins the BBC's output. As such, the BBC's **Editorial Guidance** commits to being inclusive and accessible to all disabled people.

There is also a **legal requirement** under the **2010 Equality Act** to make all websites accessible to all disabled users.

Using text descriptions has other benefits too.

- It helps with Search Engine Optimisation (SEO), because search engines are better able to index images with text descriptions.
- People on slow networks where images do not load properly, or who have images switched off, can read the text descriptions in some browsers.
- If the image does not load and the text description is visible, people using speech recognition software can target image buttons or links by including the text description in the voice command.

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No 'one-size-fits-all' approach

There's no ideal word count for text descriptions. The information needed depends on the context and content of the story. For example, consider an image of a bird.

- If the story is about the countryside, it might not need a detailed text description.
- If the story is about types of birds, it will be important to describe its appearance.
- If the story is about types of birds but there's a good description of that bird within the body of the text, the text description won't need to be as detailed.

What type of image is it?

There are five types, with their own guidance.

- **Decorative images** – images that are only included for aesthetic reasons, like stock images and graphics for style.
- **Informative images** – images that communicate information, convey a mood, or add to the user experience, like photos of relevant scenery, people and objects.
- **Functional images** – images of interactive elements, like links or buttons.
- **Images of text** – images where text is burned into the image and can't be read by screen readers or braille displays, like screenshots or charts.
- **Complex images** – images that convey detailed factual information, like graphs, charts, maps and infographics.

You might also be **describing people**.

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How blind people use screen readers

A screen reader is software that converts digital text into speech or braille output and allows blind people to navigate and access different types of content.

When a blind user visits a webpage, the screen reader interprets the underlying HTML code and vocalises the text, allowing them to hear the information. Users navigate through the content using keyboard commands or gestures.

To understand images, screen readers rely on alternative text descriptions provided by website developers or anyone using a content management system to create content. When encountering an image, the screen reader reads the alt text aloud, providing context to the user.

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Contact us

If you want to contact us about our **How To Write Text Descriptions (alt text)** guides please email us at **alttext.descriptions@bbc.co.uk**.

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